Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Paul Smith

Pianist Paul Smith was born in San Diego on April 17, 1922. He received classical training as a youth and after military service began performing with Les Paul, Tommy Dorsey, Louie Bellson and numerous others. Paul has established a reputation as a superlative accompanist and he has recorded with Ella Fitzgerald, Anita O'Day and Steve Allen. He spent many years in television and movie studios while keeping his jazz chops sharp with Clark Terry, Stan Kenton and Zoot Sims. He current lives in the Los Angeles area and enjoys the luxury of performing with the cream of west coast musicians.

Paul was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 14, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Los Angeles. I'm pleased to have Paul Smith with me today.

PS: It's my pleasure to be here, in fact it's my pleasure to be anywhere.

MR: All right. Well you just were saying off-camera that being healthy is job number one these days, or something like that.

PS: Well it always has been from my standpoint. I'm one of the oddball musicians that went through the whole big band scene and everything, never smoked, never drank and hated drug addicts, so that was it.

MR: Well I think longevity is pretty important.

PS: Well it will get you past 70 anyway.

MR: Right.

PS: Hopefully it will get us past 80.

MR: At this point in your musical career you're able to just pick and choose the things you want to do?

PS: Yeah. About 1972, I was working the studios for many years, and in 1972 I came home one day and I said to my wife "do you realize that I've worked almost every day this month and I haven't touched a piano?" Because of the Moog, all the synthesizers, the ARP and all the electronic instruments. And I didn't enjoy playing electronic instruments particularly so I said I think we can afford now to not do that. I had done it for many, many years so I decided I'd just play piano from 1972 on and that would be it — acoustic piano, as the modernists call it, but it's still THE piano.

MR: That's a very interesting way you put that. I mean I've heard people talk about electronics in the studio and so forth, but to have not touched an acoustic piano for a month.

PS: Yeah. And you run in there and you've got everything in the so-called old days back in the late 40s, 50s, 60s, all your doubles in the studios. I mean once in a while you got to play a Hammond organ and celeste, and then I think the first electronic instrument was the Novachord. And that was kind of a dull thing to play also. The only advantage to it was it had a stop on there where you could delay your sound, the sound would come out about an eighth note late, and you could play perfectly with a string section, because string sections follow the conductor and they're about an eighth note behind the actual downbeat. You know it's like daah — they play on the upbeat, and it's hard to do if you're a timekeeper. So if you can play in time and push that key and the key sounds an eighth later, you're right with the strings.

MR: Great. I'd never heard that.

PS: It wasn't particularly much fun to play, that particular instrument, but I mean it did work that way, if they needed it to blend in with the strings. Because the strings, I mean, it's just a fact of life that they play just that little bit behind because of the conductor.

MR: Yeah, you don't get Taa, you kind of get a little—

PS: You can get that if you tell them ahead of time, I mean the good string players, like the guys that do the studios and also the symphonies and all that, I mean if you say I want it when my hand hits the belt buckle, I mean I want boom here, rather than, daaa, on the upbeat, well they'll come through for you, because they're all good musicians.

MR: Did you have to become involved in the manipulation of the electronic instruments? Learning to program and all that kind of stuff?

PS: No, that's the reason I got out of it. I really didn't want to become an electrician and I didn't want to become a sound effects man. In fact one of the first time I played in one of the movies, I've forgotten which one, the conductor said, "you've got four bars of wind?" And I thought wait a minute, you know, what is this [scats]. You're a sound effects man. And I still like to play music, and I still love piano, so I thought well this is a good time to just kind of back out of that, just play piano and play with whom I like. I spent most of my life being an accompanist, probably since 1950 when I was out at NBC, we were on staff out there and we had eight shows a week with eight different singers. Everybody had a musical show out there. So it was a lot of fun. You got to play for a lot of people. I played everybody from Dorothy Kirsten, Lawrence Melchior, Dinah Shore, Ella, and then all the other shows out there, Gisele MacKenzie, Gordon MacRae, Tony Martin, Nat Cole had a half hour show, you know everybody had a show.

MR: Now not all piano players make good accompanists.

PS: It's a different bag completely actually.

MR: Is it possible to put into words what you take into account when you're playing behind a singer?

PS: Well I wrote a book for the Mel Bay group, publishers, called *The Pianist's Handbook* which was for accompanists really. And it didn't sell because there aren't that many accompanists out there that are going to buy a book on accompanying. But I have found throughout the years that the best philosophy on that is to play ten percent of what you're capable of playing, behind a singer. There's one soloist, that's her, you have to bury what ego you might have to want to show off what you can do, and make the singer sound as good as you can and stay out of her or his way. And the art of accompanying is nothing more than just holding back. When they aren't singing you play a couple of notes, and when they are singing, stay out of their way. It's very simple really, if you think about it.

MR: Did you learn that by trial and error? Did you have people telling you, singers saying, hey let's—

PS: No I started accompanying at the age of about 14, I mean in high school. I had a disastrous experience, which only a musician would appreciate. I had a boy singer who wanted to sing "Stardust" in the key of D flat, and as all musicians know the melody starts on a C and goes up, and the first chord is a G flat. So I gave him a big A flat seventh, naturally going into D flat, figuring, and he starting on the A flat see? Now that puts him in the key of either D or A, I forgot which one. And at 14 years old you don't transpose real great you know. Luckily I had an ear and I kind of staggered through the thing.

MR: That's not the easiest tune to fake in a new key either.

PS: So at that moment I realized that I mean you kind of have to take over with a singer, and give them maybe a bell tone, depending on how good their ear is, and if not the bell tone, just make sure that they know where to come in. And if they start on the second beat of a tune you have to play the downbeat. You can't sit and look at each other and wait for that downbeat, you have to take over. So it's been kind of a fun adventure.

MR: Yeah. You're walking a fine line between leading them—

PS: And the real good singers are really no problem. The ones that really have talent are very easy to work with. The ones that don't have talent are the ones that are difficult because they're insecure up there. And singing is a whole different musical situation. My wife is a singer, Annette Warren, and her description of being up there with your bare face hanging out is different than me — I have a piano between me and an audience. But when you're out there, there you are, and you're at the mercy of that guy sitting at the piano. He can butcher you if he plays too much. If he tries to be a second soloist at the same time, why you're in a lot of trouble.

MR: Well you've certainly played behind some of the greats. When you were growing up in Southern California, what kind of music were you hearing over the airwaves?

PS: Mostly the Benny Goodman type of thing. When I was a teenager I guess about 16, 17, 18, 19, in that area, that would be the late 30s, very early 40s, Glenn Miller, the old Glen Gray Casa Loma band, my favorite band of all was Jimmie Lunceford and Basie was around. I used to go out to the Mission Beach Ballroom with a friend of mine who liked all kinds of music but mainly swing, which was the thing in those days. And we'd stand under the bandstand for four hours, get a good spot under there at nine o'clock and we wouldn't move until one o'clock when they quit, and just listen. And you could do that with the bands like Lunceford and Basie and Glen Gray had an exciting band. He had Sonny Dunham who was one of the first high note artists. The Lunceford band had Paul Webster, who was probably the original high note artist I guess, with the double C's and all that. We used to get a big thrill out of that. It was an unusual sound.

MR: Were you forced into playing the piano or did it come—

PS: No it was kind of fun. At the time, I don't really remember how I started. I mean my folks tell me that I used to go over to the — they had a little ricca R-I-C-C-A piano. I've never seen one since. It was a good little upright. And my folks were in vaudeville. They were both very musical. My dad played trumpet and did comedy and my mom was a singer, and a very good one, judging from the press clipping they had in vaudeville, there are books of clippings and they're all rave reviews so I guess they were very good. But they saw the handwriting on the wall when movies came in that vaudeville was going to be doomed and my dad being the brain that he was, he graduated from Boston Latin School in the east there, so you can go to any college that you want if you get out of Boston Latin School, they'll love to have you. And he always wanted to be a newspaperman and write stories and all that. So he got a job on the *San Diego Union* as a cub reporter at about 15 bucks a week after having been in vaudeville making quite a lot more.

MR: 15 bucks a week, huh?

PS: He finally became the Sunday editor of the paper, and bless their hearts they chose San Diego to settle down in to have children. And my mom had one giant child and then that's all she could handle, that was me, I was an only child. I was almost ten pounds and my mother was five feet tall.

MR: That's enough of that, right?

PS: She used to say, "where did you come from?" My dad was six feet. But they tell me I went to the piano and rather than do this on it, I would play with the fingers. Not necessarily —

MR: Your own brand of counterpoint.

PS: Not Paderewski, but — so they thought well maybe he's got a little talent. And between the two of them I should have. And they gave me lessons starting at eight. I took lessons from the time I was eight until sixteen, and at sixteen I just kind of went on my own from there on. And the teacher I owe most of it to I mean was a guy named Royal Brown who was the city organist at San Diego. And I used to take a lesson after he got through with his afternoon concerts. He used to play "The Well Tempered Clavichord" [Clavier] and all these kind of things, all the Bach stuff. He was a master of Bach on a five manual organ at Balboa Park on Wednesdays Saturdays and Sundays, and then once a week I would meet him in the back there, either there or at his house depending on what day I took my lesson, and he would give me a real legit 45 minute lesson. He would never play anything for me, because I was born with a photographic mind so that if he played something for me I didn't have to read it, I could play it back at him.

MR: Did he discover this up front, where you demonstrated that ability and he decided that's not what we need here.

PS: Yeah. Because strangely enough at the age of about 14 I knew what I wanted to do. I didn't want to sit in a nightclub and play jazz. I wanted to be in the studios.

MR: No kidding?

PS: That was my main goal in life. And I made it, in about 1950 I got into my first studio thing and I stayed in the studios for about 20 years. But he was very smart, he let me play 45 minutes of all the technical stuff, the Hanon and Czerny and all this and the Bach and Mozart, it was mostly technical stuff. He never pushed me into learning by rote or either way, the Rachmaninoff and the heavy stuff that you have to spend weeks and weeks and weeks before you can play the thing. And he just worked on my facility and then the last 15 minutes he'd let me play my pop books, which was very smart of him. And I had Nat Cole and Tatum and Eddie Duchin, and all the pianists of the day at the time, you know Tatum of course is all our Gods, and there's never been and I don't think there will ever be another man with two right hands.

MR: Amazing. The Tatum books, had someone transcribed the music? When you say you were reading Tatum books.

PS: I wasn't — I was just playing the simple part of the Tatum books.

MR: Okay. It had the chord symbols?

PS: There weren't too many chord symbols back in the real early days of that, I mean it was pretty much the reading, and I realized very early in life if you have the ability to improvise, which is something you're born with, I mean that's not something you acquire, that's just a little thing that's handed to you on a platter and I mean you can't

take credit for it, except what you do with it. I mean if you foster it, it works out pretty good.

MR: So would you take exception to the pretty well known music educator out now who puts out this series, that's called "Anyone Can Improvise?"

PS: Yeah I would disagree with that. I spent a while teaching there, and several of the students wanted to improvise and I said let me play a C chord — boom. What do you hear? What does your mind tell you play against that C chord? And most people play C-E-G. Those are the three notes of the C chord.

MR: Right.

PS: And a couple of them played a little bit of something, but the mind doesn't work that way. But if your mind works in an improvisational way and hears a whole lot of things, you can play a concerto on a C chord. But it is something you're born with. You can learn a lot of licks, you can listen to Oscar and the guys that are at the top of the jazz scene, and Oscar will play [scats] — so I can sound just like Oscar, but I mean that's not improvising. Playing something he played, then he might as well write it out for me and I'll play it. You steal a few licks from everybody and I have about six Tatum CDs that I have on all the time, and whenever I'm not doing anything else, where I just sit in my den, I listen to Tatum. Not that I want to imitate him, but you find chord changes he makes that you wouldn't think of. I mean I've been in the business a long time, I know an awful lot of chord changes, but he knows a lot more than I do.

MR: He's got the really hip substitutions, huh?

PS: A guy says, "I heard Tatum and I want to cut my fingers off." I said, "I hear him and I want to practice like heck."

MR: There's the attitude.

PS: That's the only way you go. I mean there's always somebody that's going to play a hell of a lot more than you do. Like today, to me the best jazz pianist going today is Oscar. Bar none. I don't make any exceptions with that. That's with jazz. For the best all around pianist I think is Dick Hyman, who has all the bases covered. And then Peter Nero is excellent, Roger Williams for what Roger does I think is great. Because I don't think Roger was a natural, Roger had to practice one heck of a lot to play the way he plays, to get to where he got, it took a lot of work, but he got there. And he's gotten better and better as he's gone along. He cut away from the vanilla chords. He sent me an album of his one time "On A Clear Day," and I just tell him, my God, you know the harmonic thing was such a change from "Autumn Leaves" and the kind of commercial things he did you know. He was very successful commercially, in other words I mean his harmonic changes, which don't really mean too much to the general public — you can play four

chords, especially today, you can play four chords to the general public and they think you're wonderful today.

MR: How did you get into the big band scene? You played with Dorsey and Charlie Shavers.

PS: I got into — I was 19 years old I think if I recall, yeah, 1941. Actually I started in the business basically as an arranger. The piano was a little bit secondary. I bought a book on arranging when I was a kid by Frank Skinner, and I had a band in high school, and another arranger, Frank Comstock was in the same harmony class I was in down there and he and I were friends. And he had a band too. I don't know whether you're familiar with Frank, but he did a whole lot of stuff for Les Brown when he was very young, and he did a lot of stuff for Jack Webb, which for some reason was kind of the kiss of death. You know when Webb died I mean everything just kind of turned off, and there's no reason for it because this guy can really write beautifully.

MR: Jack Webb Productions?

PS: Yeah. You know he did "Dragnet" and "Emergency" and—

MR: I see. He was even in that movie, "Pete Kelly's Blues." Do you remember that? But getting back, you were a pretty self directed young man then.

PS: Yeah I did pretty well what I wanted to do, and I mean getting back to 1941, I don't really remember how it happened, but I had a chance to audition for Ozzie Nelson. And I went up and played and he liked the way I played, and the thing I think that made me stay with the band, you know I wrote an arrangement for him. And Ozzie had always had one of those Dick Jurgens type bands, I mean the people danced and it was a nice dance band and he had a style where the baritone player was always roving around on the bass clef while the band was playing, I mean that was kind of the distinctive style of the band, but it was kind of a dull band from a standpoint of swinging or anything you know. I wrote a thing for him called "Rasputin's Laundry." It's a great title you know. This was in 1941. But it was a Lunceford type thing.

MR: It was an original tune?

PS: Yeah. Just a thing I whipped up, you know [scats] but the dotted eighths and sixteenths that Lunceford used to play. And he broke it in at Evichen's Garden up in Denver. And for the first time in his history, the audience gathered around the bandstand and clapped at the end of the thing instead of just dancing around like they usually did. And his statement to me, he said, "I don't understand the music," but he said, "write some more like that."

MR: Oh, that's great. It almost sounds like a little movie scene.

PS: And ironically I did Ricky's first record with Ozzie in the booth. And when Ricky did his first tune Ozzie turned to me and he said, "now you know how I felt about your writing."

Because he didn't know what Ricky was doing with the rock scene. I mean Ozzie was totally out of that you know. And he said that was the same feeling he had when that "Rasputin's Laundry" came to this band.

MR: He was a bit mystified but he knew if it was working though I guess.

PS: Yeah. I ended up writing an entire library for him. He went into the Biltmore Bowl which was kind of the place at that time in town here, but a very commercial thing. And the first instruction was, "don't write the lead trumpet above an F below high C." And everything was in buckets pretty much so it was quiet. They didn't want loud music but they wanted it to swing a little you know.

MR: Well that's a challenge.

PS: Yeah.

MR: To write stuff swinging when it's soft.

PS: Sure and not be spraying your trumpets up in high C's and high D's and all of that. But that was my first big band. And then I got drafted. And at the time — there's a little story with this if you're interested. Ozzie and Harriet had their own show. And I was stationed in Long Beach so conceivably maybe I could get up to them, while I was in an Army band. But unfortunately there was no way that I could keep writing the bridges and cues and everything, and I had written the bridges and cues for Ozzie's band when he had "The Red Skelton Show" prior to his own show. So when he got his own show I had to step out. And the guy that took over for me was Billy May, who was playing trumpet in the band when I was writing for it, and we kind of reversed roles. He was playing trumpet and I was writing all the stuff in the band, and then he took over and you know what happened with Billy, I mean he's one of the best writers in the business bar none.

MR: Did Ozzie have you on a salary?

PS: Yeah.

MR: Or were you paid by the piece?

PS: Oh you mean arranging wise?

MR: Yeah.

PS: No it was just kind of a stock thing. I mean back in those days I think I got $35 a chart, and I copied it too.

MR: That's time consuming, yeah.

PS: But thirty-five bucks then would be like thirty-five hundred now.

MR: So you felt like man this is, I'm doing great here.

PS: Well I went on the road with him I think for eight weeks. I made $110 a week and I sent 80 home every week. I lived on 30 bucks, like a king. Anything I wanted to eat, anywhere I wanted to eat, hotels, the whole thing, 30 dollars. This is 1942. And then I got

drafted, and I mean luckily I got into an Army band. We had Ziggy Elman, Charlie Teagarden, and a bunch of the studio guys, the lead alto, Blake Reynolds from Paramount, lead alto from Fox, Russ Cheever, a couple of the guys, Red Ballard and Bruce Squires who were the two trombones in Benny's band, so we had one heck of a band down there. We had a radio show every week and I got to write for it and also play. So I spent two years like that and then because I was healthy after they disbanded the band in 1944, why I mean two of us went into Infantry and I ended up being a military cop over in Germany.

MR: Okay, I was going to ask if you got overseas. I seems like most of the musicians that I've talked to made out pretty well during their military service, that they were able to keep their music up in some respects.

PS: Yeah, well I kept it up the first two years. The last year I really didn't play a lot. I was a guard at a prison camp over in Heilbronn, Germany for a while, and the Division band came by and I went up and asked the leader if I could sit in. And it looked pretty funny you know, a fairly good sized slob of an MP that says "hey can I sit in with your band?" What choice did they have? The guy says "well okay." And the fingers were still working luckily. So he put a requisition in and got me out of the military police and back into a place called Seckenheim, which was called Special Service City. And Special Service City, we used to get Broadway shows in which would go out and entertain the troops and we had to cut the orchestrations down from the Broadway size to whatever we had available, like a ten piece band, and then re-orchestrate it, and then send them on the road. Well we worked like crazy for a couple of weeks doing this whole thing, and then we'd be off for like four or five weeks until the next show came in and send this one out. And another guy and I had a two piano thing down in, not Heilbronn, Heidelberg, which was an open city, they hadn't bombed there so I mean the GI's took over the Officer's Club and we had to beautiful, big German pianos down there, and we'd go down and play two pianos at the Officer's Club and get paid a small amount for it, but it was fun to do.

MR: Was there much mixing with the German population?

PS: Not an awful lot. We dated a few German gals at the time. But there was a guy named Joe Bari in the outfit with us in Seckenheim, and Barry is the grandfather's name with Tony Bennett, I mean that was Tony. He was in the Army. And I said, "why did you go in the Army under the name of Joe Bari?" Well at the time there was a little bit of racial thing with the Italians back in those days. And then to go into the Army as Anthony D. Benedetto, he figured it would be easy as just Joe Bari. So he went under the name of Joe Bari all the time he was in the Army.

MR: I'll be darned.

PS: And he was singing good even then, this was clear back in ’45.

MR: Did you notice, was there a resentment from the German population towards Americans, or didn’t you have to deal with that?

PS: We didn’t deal too much with the population. I mean other than Patton set up this prison camp in Heilbronn and we had a half a million prisoners in there, not all Germans, some Hungarians and what have you. And periodically we had to go in there and find the SS men that were amongst them that had been captured, because I mean nobody would talk, nobody would say anything if there was an SS man around. So they picked some of the bigger guys and three or four of us would go in there unarmed and find the SS men, and get them out, and then everybody would be much happier inside there.

MR: Oh yeah. And this was like a temporary holding place for these soldiers until eventually—

PS: Yeah. At the end of the war they were down to, I mean we had from eight years old to high eighties, they were using the bottom of their manpower barrel. For a while they were strapping kids in trees you know, and it was fun for the kids until, you know, they’d get to shoot out of the trees there, and then a GI would let a few shots go and a kid would fall out of the tree, and that didn’t make them feel too good. But unfortunately that’s part of war. As my dad used to say, as long as there’s two human beings on the earth we’re going to have war. It’s the nature of the beast unfortunately. Animals don’t have wars, only people.

MR: Well you came back, got out of the service in ’45.

PS: ’46 I got out actually, yeah.

MR: And in 1946, I had noticed this note and I wrote, the following band leaders called it quits: Woody Herman, Benny Goodman, Harry James, Les Brown, Benny Carter, Jack Teagarden, and so forth and so on. Was this something you guys noticed?

PS: No I don’t think they called it quits — I think the big band era started to go in actually about ’48. When I got out of the Army I mean and I had the chance to audition for Les Paul, who at the time had a jazz trio. And I went up and luckily, thanks to my teacher and the technique he taught me you know, I could keep up with Les. And his idea of a ballad was about here [claps]. So I played with the group. We started at a place called the Rounders Club, which was literally at the corner of Sunset and Vine at the time, and then we went out on the road as the opening act for the Andrews Sisters, and I kind of graduated, suddenly I became the Andrews Sisters’ accompanist, which was like being with The Beatles, you know, because the adoration and fan support was unbelievable. And when I came back the Andrews Sisters had acquired a five day a week radio show, I think it was Club 15 or something was the name of it. And I wasn’t real sure at the time

whether my reading ability, that would be like the first studio work, working on a radio show. That's what I wanted to do eventually. And we had about a three week break there before we started the show and I went back to San Diego and I got a call from a guy who had been the trombonist way early with Ozzie Nelson, who he was playing trombone for Tommy Dorsey's band, and he was kind of a road manager. And he called me up and he said, "we're coming into town next Friday" and he said, "would you like to play one night with the band there?" He said, "Tommy just fired his pianist from Ocean Park up here and he doesn't have a pianist." And he said, "I told him about you, and he said get the kid and we'll give him a shot." So I said, "gee that'd be fun." So when the band came down to San Diego I went down sight unseen, hadn't seen the book or anything. And the first thing the old man did was try to burn me out. I mean in other words he did this kind of a test with all the guys that played solo in the band, like DeFranco and Charlie Shavers and Ziggy and all. So he picked up a tune, the very first tune was a blues thing that Charlie Shavers had written, and it was at a fairly uptempo from his standpoint, it was like a ballad to me, having played with Les. And he would do this at you, five choruses. Okay. He played five choruses. Ten more. You played ten more. And he'd have you play 30, 40 choruses. And most guys after about ten choruses at about this tempo [claps], they begin to slow down. And I'd been doing that, I could do that with one hand. Because that was a ballad tempo with Les. So when they ended the first set, the trombone, Wes Cope was his name, he came over and he said, "the old man wants to know if you want to join the band." And I thought this would be a great experience because he was playing a lot of vaudeville shows at the time. Like when the band would go out it would be Tommy Dorsey and his Orchestra featuring such-and-such dancers, the Step Brothers, we played with them. And you've got to read their music.

MR: In addition to playing with Dorsey, you've got to play the other people's music.

PS: Yeah, you play the whole show. It's an hour show, mainly featuring the band, but the band would play an opener and maybe one tune that was familiar to them "Well Get It" or something, and then you go into your acts. And there's a whole variety of acts you have to play and a lot of their music is written on papyrus and it's also written in blue chalk, you know, it's terrible stuff to read. But it's great experience. It's the best experience I had. And I stayed with them in '47 and '48, two years, reading all this funny stuff. So I felt I would be more capable when I came back to L.A. to do some studio work, which is immediate sight reading. I mean that's why it's a closed corporation. I mean you walk in there at nine o'clock in the morning and there it is, and you play it once to make sure the copyist didn't make any mistakes, and then you record, and that's it.

MR: No mistakes for you.

PS: Yeah. And I mean you play the thing through, and if you play a wrong note, the wrong note is written there, I mean you catch it and you correct those before you record. That's all. But for some guys it's very nerve-wracking. So you have to have a cast iron stomach and a sense of humor I always say to be a studio player. And I found it's the same thing with jazz. If you have a sense of humor you can have a lot of fun in jazz. Jazz has to be fun as far as I'm concerned. I don't have any desire to be real serious about it and tell big stories about it, because I mean basically it's still the blues.

MR: It's still the blues. Curious you say that because we've in the past years, it's being elevated to a real art form, in the universities and with Jazz at Lincoln Center and all that.

PS: Well it's like jazz basically, if you really get down to the nitty gritty of the thing, it's nothing more than creating a new melody out of your head on a basic set of chords, either from another tune or chords that you write yourself. But that's it. There's no great story with it, I don't think. I mean I've never been able to — you know the guys that really took it seriously and really didn't work to an audience, killed it for a long time there, especially the bop era. I blame the bop era for the advent of rock, see, because the kids at that time, when bop came in, there was no time, outside of Parker and Gillespie. I mean they played in pretty good time. Then the guys got into this real fast [scats] without regard to being able to pop your fingers and be able to dance. You couldn't dance to bop for anything. And the kids were left with actually nothing. So I mean they picked up their guitars, which is the easiest thing to learn and keep time with [scats] and that's where rock came in. It came in in the bop era. And the only thing that could have prevented that would have been Jobim with the bossa nova, but the bossa nova was too hard. It takes time to learn those chord changes and to be able to play that real subtle type of thing. You know on guitar you can go spang-a-lang and it's no problem. You learn C, G and F and you've got it. We used to have a lot of garage bands with the kids, and if the bass player couldn't make it why the guitar player and the drummer would flip a coin and one of them would be the bass player that night. That's the way it started. Granted, it's gotten better but I mean my personal feeling is we could have done without it.

MR: But the youth wanted their own music and since it wasn't being offered to them—

PS: Yeah. And bop was not the answer. And the big bands, see the big bands are starting to come back a little bit, not from the standpoint of being popular and being able to travel, I mean today it's impossible to really move a band.

MR: Yeah. Way too expensive.

PS: Sixteen guys with airfare from here to Podunk or you know, it's not going to work. But the kids are kind of discovering the fun of dancing together instead of opposite ends of the hall.

MR: Great statement. When you got back into the studios, had the music changed much from when you were working with Ozzie?

PS: Well Ozzie was in the 40s. In the 50s, the 50s actually were the best time as far as I'm concerned. I never came home complaining about the music on the date. I got to work with Johnny Green and Max Steiner and Alfred Newman, Lionel Newman, and the guys, you'd go in and there'd be a big beautiful string section and everything, and you're part of it. It was just lovely to do. It wasn't until about the early 60s that it started to deteriorate and get into the eighth triplet syndrome [scats], and the oohs and the aahs with the group. But when the eighth triplets came in I could see the handwriting on the wall. Because I did one date where the piano was facing the conductor and he had — this whole thing was eighth triplets [scats]. And the band. And just as a gag I took off my loafer and put it on my hand so I'm playing with a shoe. And he can't see. And I'm going ching-ching-ching-ching— with a shoe on my hand. I played the entire date that way and when I first did it I looked at him kind of like — and he said great, that's the sound he wants. And I'm playing with a shoe. So I had a faint idea what was coming up. I mean he never knew and I certainly never told him, but I could have sent one of my kids in with a shoe and play duh-duh-duh-duh and stop when he does this, and that's it. So I could see what music was coming to at that time.

MR: I have to ask the obvious question to me, is what key was that piece in if you were playing with your shoe on?

PS: It doesn't make any difference. It's just the sound, ching-ching-ching. I didn't make any chord changes. The shoe covered part — it was mostly on the black keys, but the lower part was on the white. So you have white and black both [scats]. But all he could hear was ching-ching-ching-ching— and that's the sound he wanted. It didn't make any difference what notes they were, playing a G chord or a D chord or anything like that, just ching-ching-ching that's it.

MR: That six-eight feel was kind of a — was it because it was a good dance feel? Is that why that became a thing?

PS: I don't really know. I mean I went up to him after the date and told him not to call me on those kind of dates anymore. Because I had to go right from there over and play something, and I mean I'd been playing with a shoe on my hand or [scats] and then go over and have to play something at NBC for some singer, and you'd come in like this. So I said don't call me on those triplet date. You've got a musical date I'll be happy to do it. I mean it cost me a lot of money but I'd rather come home happy than irritated.

MR: Gosh, that's very interesting. I'm looking at some of the recordings. You had a recording in '53, was it "Fine, Sweet and Tasty?" Was this under your name?

PS: Yeah. That's one I just barely remember. It has come up constantly. I mean the first one that really was a semi-commercial success was "Liquid Sounds" which I did for Capitol, which was a little Bach group actually. It was six men, rhythm section, guitar, piano, bass, drums and a flute and clarinet. And I wrote the thing sometimes in four part harmony with electric guitar, piano, flute and clarinet, kind of like a sax section, and other times we have the counterpuntal stuff going on between the clarinet and guitar or flute and piano or whatever combination worked.

MR: That counterpuntal type of writing seemed to ring a bell in the industry for a while.

PS: Yeah, well that hadn't been done at that time. I mean it was kind of a novel group. I mean it wasn't a group I would take on the road because I deliberately wanted to be around my family. That's one of the reasons I always wanted to be in the studio, so I could go home at night. I don't want to be out in the middle of Iowa someplace in a club and then have to go back to the hotel. And at that time they allowed smoking in clubs so that really drove me up the wall.

MR: Did you have children at this time?

PS: Yeah. We have three. One we lost in 1988 in an accident, but we have three, two boys and a girl and five grandchildren.

MR: So it was important to go home for you.

PS: Yeah. I mean I went out for four years, 1972 to '76 with Sammy, mainly because it was so much fun. It was probably the most fun job I've ever had in my life.

MR: Sammy Davis you're talking about?

PS: Yeah. I mean he and I had a thing going there that was just — I couldn't wait to get on the stand at night. Because it kept growing. It started off and the guitar had a lot of things with him when I first joined the thing, and then gradually the guitar was put aside and the piano came in and then pretty soon about half of the show was just him and piano. And it was a challenge all the time. The people would shout a request to him, a tune he didn't know and I didn't know, and we'd try to do it. And it was so much fun. He had a great statement which could apply to jazz or anything else when he said, "we ain't doing Hamlet up here, have fun." And there was never a night that we didn't have fun. I mean originally I went with him just for a couple of concerts. His conductor called me and this was 1972 right after I decided I was going to bounce the studios and just play piano when and where I liked, and then I get this call. He said, "we've got a couple of concerts next week, would you like to do them?" I didn't even ask about money or anything else. I said, "fine." He said, "well the first one's in Berlin, the other one is in Paris." I said, "fine, send me a ticket." And the plane was like twelve hours late so I got there about maybe an hour and a half ahead of the concert, went in and read his whole book that night. But at

that time my reading was good so it was no problem. And then when I came back after the two concerts I thought well that's it. Then I got a call from him and Louie Bellson was playing drums on both the concerts there, and Louie's an old friend because he was with the Dorsey band when I was there, and we traveled together. I bought a convertible and he and I would travel away from the band, because he's a non-smoker, non-drinker also, and we couldn't stand it. I went on the bus once, that was it, with the booze and the smoke, I said I can't make this, I've got to be out in the open. So I said, "Lou, you want to drive?" He said, "yeah." He would sit in the back seat of the convertible with a drum pad and practice while I'm driving you know. That's why he's as good as he is. He really took some time. He had that drum pad with him all the time. And as good as he played then, he was still practicing all the time.

MR: You were with his band '61 and '78.

PS: Who, Tommy?

MR: Louie Bellson? With his own big band?

PS: No I never worked with Louie's big band. I never worked with him there. Dorsey I was with in '47 and '48, and then '49 I came out and starred for a year with the rest of the Kenton guys. They couldn't get into the studios either for the first year or so. I mean I came in with a reputation as being a bop pianist, and being an arranger earlier, I used to play my saxophone parts on piano to hear what they sounded like, so I learned to play that blocked thing, legato, that George does. And Shearing at that time was on Discovery Records and he moved to Capitol and they hired me to come in and record at Discovery because I could play the Shearing style. I used to say I'm the White Shearing.

MR: The White Shearing.

PS: But that was my first record contact. The first record company I was ever with was Discovery with Albert Marks. I played for David Allen, who was one heck of a singer. You didn't hear too much about him, another case of being too good. That's the case today I think. Because none of the real fine singers have record contracts. Jack Jones I think doesn't have a contract, Steve and Eydie don't have a contract. And I mean they're all, from my standpoint, they're the best singers around.

MR: Tell me about working with Ella if you don't mind.

PS: That was a total delight. Musically you can't beat it. I mean it spoiled you for most other singers. She was such an easy person to play for. I mean that was a case, I mean when she's scatting, you play one-fifteenth of what you're capable of playing. We did one album together, which I bought three or four copies of for posterity for my family and everything, and it's called "The Intimate Ella," and it's just piano and her. And it's the one album where nobody plays choruses. I mean most, I'd say 99% of her albums, she

was the band singer. The band played 16 bars, or if it was done with Oscar or Joe Pass or whoever, I mean they played choruses and they played behind her, and it was kind of like a coordinated thing between them but it wasn't really her album. And this one, she loved to sing ballads. And I don't think she had ever done a complete ballad album, she always ended up having to scat or having to do swinging things. So we did like 15 tunes, all ballads. And she was at the height of her career at that time. And I said, "I'm going to play four bars, and you sing. There's no piano choruses, nobody else, this is just you, you just do what you want to do." And it turned out to be — I mean it's a singer's tour de force. Every singer should listen to that whole album. That's where the statement came from she could sing the telephone book and make it sound good. Because she did all the tunes that people have trouble with — "Melancholy Baby," "Who's Sorry Now," and the "Black Coffee," "One for the Road." It's just a beautiful album, not because I'm on it but just from the singing standpoint she was exquisite and singing just what she wanted to sing. She didn't want to do any scat, didn't want any tunes where she had to ad lib. She did her little ad libs, which she does on ballads, but generally it's straight melody pretty much. And it's a great album for her.

MR: Great. I'll have to look for that one.

PS: I'm glad we did the thing.

MR: Yes. You've had a relationship with Steve Allen too, ongoing?

PS: Yes. Steve Allen inherited me. We had a show at NBC back in I guess about 1965 I guess it was, with Pat Boone, who I had also worked with. And Pat had a five day a week show at NBC and he was signed up for 13 weeks and I came in with the band. Well you don't think of Pat Boone as having a band that has Frank Capp, Barney Kessel and Ray Brown and me for a rhythm section. Plus some very good players. And it was only about a ten-piece band. But at the end of the 13 weeks they decided to let Pat go and they put Steve in to replace him. And when Steve heard the band he kept us on, because I mean he's strictly music. So that was my, I say well you inherited me, that's all. And we've had a very pleasant relationship. The last three or four years I've been working with him probably more than ever. I conducted three different shows that he had out here, one for Filmways and one over at KTLA. And it was just plain fun. I mean he's a great guy to work with. The sense of humor and the intellect is tremendous, and his piano playing has gotten a heck of a lot better than it was initially. He's fun to play with.

MR: Do you guys do two pianos?

PS: On the road, yeah. We usually have two pianos and he does the first part of the show with cards sent in by the audience asking him questions. I mean some of them are pretty inane. That's the way you find out about audiences.

MR: Okay here's what I'm dealing with.

PS: But he does about a half hour just with the audience alone. And then he says, "I feel like playing the piano" and he moves over, and I've been playing all this funny stuff behind him. Because a lot of the names, if we get a four syllable name, like Harry Sosneck, you know I'll go [scats] and he'll sing "Barney Google" then "Harry Sosneck" with goo-goo-googly eyes, and just little things I throw at him for laughs, and play funny music behind him. And then he'll sit down at the piano and I move over to the other piano. And generally we play two or three nice ballads, you know, the Harold Arlen type things, and then a blues thing and a boogie woogie thing and that's the end of that, and then I move back over to the other piano and he says to the audience, "now if you were a comedian, would you bring another comedian in now?" He says, "If you were a pianist, would you bring another pianist on now? Yes you would." And then he gives me this huge build-up and I play one tune, usually "Green Dolphin Street" with just whatever rhythm section we have, we pick them up generally when we go out, we just get bass and drums. And I do my shot and then he sings three or four of his hit songs and we're off.

MR: It seems like you've had some very fortunate working situations throughout your career that really gave you what you needed for the rest of your career.

PS: Yeah. Well I said I've been lucky I've been able to play with all the people that I used to look up to when I was a teenager. Like I thought Basie was the greatest thing in life and when I was in the Army, one of the bass players in the Army, Walt Yoder had worked with Woody's band and he knew all the guys in the Basie band and he took me and the guitar player, my best friend Tony Rizzi, out to the ballroom to see Basie, and he arranged for us to sit in. I mean I'm like 20 years old and Basie's one of my idols, and the only way you can play with Basie's band is to play like Basie. I don't care what other style you play. So I just did my Basie bit. I did an intro, you know [scats] and the tenths and all that routine. And Basie, being a very nice guy, I mean I got to know him very well because we did a lot of work with him with Ella, Basie and Ella were together a lot. And I told him about, you know I said when I was a kid and I sat in with your band, you came up to me after the set I played and you said, "hey kid, you trying to take my job?" That's the nicest thing you could say. I had another experience with a trumpet player who had his own band when I was a kid and I went up on the stage and I said Mr. so-and-so, "how do you pick the guys in your band?" He says, "get away, don't bother me." Well this guy ended up sitting in the band in Florida playing trumpet in the band there, and I was conducting for Sammy. I never told him, naturally. It was just the difference. You know I mean that kind of an attitude I really don't appreciate. Because by your students you will be taught. And someday you may work for your students. And anybody that you can help

along in the business to avoid any of the pitfalls you might have run into, you should do it. You owe that to this business. Don't get into racial scenes. I used to be Charlie Shaver's bodyguard when we did a tour of the south. I mean I would go to the men's room with him.

MR: This was with—

PS: Dorsey. This was like late '46, '47, '48 back in there. It was still hairy down in that area. But there's really no room for that in our business. There's no room for it anywhere really, but I mean you're always going to have that problem, it's just there, but especially in our business. I mean this is a talent business, and who you are and how you play, that's it. There's no room for the competing racial type things. There's a couple going on now, you know very subtly, you know, White men can't swing and all that. But we don't need that. I mean the color line doesn't exist as far as I'm concerned, anywhere, but especially in our business.

MR: Well said. What are you listening tastes? Well you said you turn on Art Tatum all the time at home.

PS: I listen to Tatum, I listen to Oscar, I listen to Dick Hyman. Those are my three favorite pianists, as a pianist. I've got most of Peter Nero's early stuff. He did what I always wanted to do and we couldn't convince the people at CBS, I used to do all the Paul Weston dates and Paul wrote these beautiful string things. He was one of the better writers of that type of music. And we always wanted to do a piano thing with the string section and all that routine. And we couldn't sell it to CBS and then RCA came out with "New Piano in Town" Peter Nero and he did exactly what I would have loved to do. He played beautifully, the arrangements were great. Peter is one of the few guys that I still, if he's playing some place, I go see him. Because he's a good all-around player. You know you don't go in and get an hour and a half, two hours of exactly the same thing chorus after chorus. I mean I've always tried to do the same thing. I've never thought of myself as a jazz pianist, even though I play jazz. But when we do concerts, I mean part of it is, say fifty percent jazz, the rest of it is pretty melodies, bossa novas, flag wavers with wow, what's he doing up there, you know, amaze the public routines. But it's fun. And the main thing is to have fun on the stage. I've never really worked jazz clubs per se, because the people that come to jazz clubs are too serious about it. I mean the attitude has got to be a certain way, and there's a lot of guys that don't play very well that play jazz clubs and kind of fool the people that way.

MR: Music from fellows like John Coltrane that are seemingly very serious and filled with let's say messages, did that ever appeal to you?

PS: No. I like melodic, good sounds. I like a guy that gets a good sound on his instrument. Like on alto sax I mean it's hard to beat Paul Desmond with Brubeck. He got a lovely sound on the instrument. You could listen to him, he didn't get that raucous sound. A lot of guys get a very raucous sound on their instrument, which is exciting if you're playing raucous jazz, but the guys that I've always liked have gotten good sound. Like Lester Young always had a pretty sound on the instrument. Stan Getz always got a pretty sound, even Hawk. You know you can fool a lot of people by making a lot of weird sounds on your instrument, but that doesn't mean you're playing it well.

MR: Let me just follow up on something you said. Some water?

PS: Oh thank you. About this time if this was Steve going to take this drink, I'd go write in [scats]. Steve would say, "no, it's not booze, it's just orange juice."

MR: Some vaudeville things will never die, huh?

PS: No. That's half the fun.

MR: Just following up quickly on a thing you mentioned about Charlie Shavers and Dorsey in the south, were there incidents where you had to really come to bat for him?

PS: Well Dorsey was very good at that. That's one thing — Tommy would not stand for any hassles of Charlie. He was the only guy in the band that had a tan and when you play in Virginia and all that routine. There was one night, I wasn't there at the time, because Louie and I were driving in our convertible, but the band stopped at a place somewhere in Virginia there and there were I guess 14 of them all together. And they ordered and the guy brought 13 dinners. And they wouldn't serve Charlie. And the old man just picked the band up and left the 13 dinners on the table there and walked out, got on the bus and left. The guy was stuck with the dinners, because they wouldn't serve Charlie. So it was still going on in the late 40s I assume. I haven't been to the south too much for any length of time since then but I mean I assume that that problem is slightly easier now. But it's a ridiculous situation.

MR: Do you get to New York to play much?

PS: I don't go to New York. I don't like New York particularly. I like the Pacific Ocean very well. I'm an old body surfer. In San Diego we have the best body surfing in the world down there, and I did that all through my — that and playing tennis — I actually probably body surfed and played tennis more than I played piano.

MR: Well you've had an amazing career and—

PS: It's been a lot of fun, it's still fun you know now, because I pretty much don't have to work with bad singers necessarily.

MR: It's been a long time since you put a shoe on.

PS: Yeah I haven't had to put a shoe on for quite a while, except on my foot.

MR: That's a great story.

PS: No that's a classic. There's a peanut butter story too. When I went to Japan with Pat Boone and after the opening show generally in Tokyo, they take you over to this geisha place where the girls perform, you know I mean it's not what people think, and then they serve a dinner. And they bring out these fish, blue fish and yellow fish and red fish and they're lying on the plate looking up at you like this. And it wasn't too appetizing. And I had this coat on with a bulge in it, and I asked the guy I said, "do you have soybean cookies?" "Oh yes." I said, "do you have coke?" I said, "soybean cookies and a coke." So they brought me the soybean cookies and a coke. I said, "do you have a knife?" "Yeah." And then I whipped out my jar of Laura Scotta Peanut Butter, and that has followed me ever since. This is clear back in the mid-60s I did this. I ran into Rosie Clooney about six months later and she'd been in Japan and she said, "I heard all about your peanut butter." Because they don't have peanut butter over there. I mean they didn't then. But I couldn't eat the Japanese food so I always carried a couple of jars of peanut butter with me to get me through.

MR: That's great. Well I want to thank you for your time today.

PS: It was my pleasure.

MR: This was a really eye opening experience. By the way do you remember the tune that you played with Ricky Nelson that one session?

PS: No. It was, I hate to tell you how long ago that was.

MR: Yeah. That was like the very beginning of his career as a teen idol though.

PS: Middle to late 50s in there you know. It was one of the early — it wasn't a really radical thing, it was just that it had that rock thing with only four chords and the guitar and the spang-a-lang and the whining and all that routine. And Ozzie was A&Ring in the booth and he made that statement, you know he said, "now you know how I felt when I heard your first arrangement." He said, "I don't know what the kid's doing but apparently it's selling."

MR: Great. Well I hope the rest of your day is good and you get some body surfing in.

PS: Oh I'm sure it will be and we're going to the Palace Verdi Symphony tonight to hear some Mendelssohn. And they're having an interesting thing, I mean they're inviting all the people who are quote friends of the symphony to kind of support the symphony, to have dinner with the musicians. I said I really need that, dinner with the musicians.

MR: Well see how long it takes the strings to hit the downbeat.

PS: The conductor Joe Valenti is a real good friend of mine, and a very good trumpet player and actually now he's switched and he's learning to play piano very well. But it will be a nice concert. And he has a few ringers that he brings in from the Hollywood area. The

first men to bolster the thing up. Because local symphonies they usually have a little problem, mainly in the strings. So he said, "I've got a really good string section for this." They're doing the Beethoven "Eroica" and I don't know what it is of Mendelssohn, some violin concerto or something. But it will be a nice program.

MR: Good. All right. Thanks for your time.

PS: It was my pleasure. Thank you for inviting me.

MR: All right.